

Contemporary Issues in Academic Libraries:

Information Literacy, Fake News, and Disinformation

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Introduction

I am not a gambling woman, but I would bet that every person I know has had a moment when they didn't trust a news headline, a sound bite, or a video they saw on social media. What I wonder, though, is how many of my family members, friends, and acquaintances believe that they are bonified fact-checkers in their own right and yet depend on singular tools or outlets for assessing the veracity of those media items. As a former data analyst, I have gathered a few approaches for differentiating between perceived and actual problems, as well as for differentiating between trustworthy and unreliable sources. Therefore, I would like to believe that I am well equipped to evaluate the legitimacy of most of the documents I encounter online despite my biases and leanings. The challenge that remains is how to ensure that as current and future librarians, academic or otherwise, we are actively supporting and responding appropriately to the needs of students and patrons who are inundated daily by unwanted opportunities to absorb misinformation but strive to be information literate.

The primary complication librarians face in responding appropriately to the issue of misinformation and its peripheral effects seems to be that information literacy is not a static concept but rather a moving target. Adding complexity to hitting this target, the ever-changing nature of how humans discover, share, and consume information requires that we remain flexible and up to date in our assessment of how best to teach various aspects of information literacy. Given the glaring erosion of public trust in the media over the past decade, current texts on misinformation and related topics reflect a renewed interest in exploring the methods that experts recommend for evaluating the accuracy of online information thereby improving digital literacy. Current and future librarians should therefore continue to educate themselves as to the most modern strategies available for maintaining a sense of civic responsibility. Strategies that point library users toward the methods and means to achieve their own individual goals for finding trustworthy sources of information in a digital setting are paramount.

To Fight or Not to Fight, That is Not the Question

Historically, librarians were the gatekeepers the public relied on to connect with reliable sources of information and analysis through locally developed collections of primary and secondary resources. Presently, the accelerated pace of modern society demands that people utilize the internet to find quick answers which places them in an environment of guideless informational abundance. Attempting to reduce the noise, individuals then become algorithmically dependent on media feeds that customize their content. This results in too much time spent on a steady stream of curated content, allowing echo chambers and filter bubbles to form leading users astray. Much of this content may contain “fake news,” a term which De Paor and Heravi (2020) explain “is often used to represent a broader landscape of false or warped information, which could be intentional (disinformation) or un-intentional (misinformation)” (pp. 2-3). Exposure to fake news and other forms of misinformation is then intensified by confirmation bias which is defined in Saunders (2023) as “the tendency of human beings to seek out and trust information which reinforces their existing worldview” (p. 479).

Beene and Greer describe this intense digital world we live in as “rhizomatic” (2021, p.6). In nature, this word carries a connotation of beauty, whereas in technological circles the term rhizomatic connotes danger. The vast interconnectedness of information online causes an overload that insulates some viewers inside media silos which raises concerns that delivering information literacy lessons has become futile. Assisting in separating fact from fiction has evolved into what some librarians describe as combat (Axelsson et al., 2021; Beene & Greer, 2021; De Paor & Heravi, 2020; Saunders, 2023). Other practitioners, such as Sullivan (2019) cast aspersions on this combative response and advocate for additional research into how librarians can respond without making assumptions thereby moving forward with strategic confidence (p. 1153).

Despite the contrast in how librarians may view approaching solutions to misinformation, they all seem to support moving away from old solutions like the Currency, Relevance, Authority, Accuracy, Purpose (CRAAP) test (Saunders, 2023, p. 488) in favor of incorporating findings from other fields that lend insight and credibility to new solutions. For example, technologists have noted that disreputable news sites mimic reputable ones, and political scientists have noted that fact-checking is not unbiased nor apolitical (Sullivan, 2019, p. 1148). Ethicists have noted that an opportunity to embed metadata that certifies or lends credibility to news sites exists. Activist and academic librarians question the efficacy of such an endeavor when weighed against the ever-increasing onslaught of misinformation (Sullivan, 2019, p.1149). Nevertheless, a librarian's instinct to fight back against misinformation as though it were a formidable foe is understandable when considering angles of thought from still other fields. Economists have noted that individuals are monetarily motivated to deliver false news stories to the public on various platforms with large audiences, and data scientists have noted that opinions are regularly being advertised as though they are facts (De Paor & Heravi, 2020, p. 3). Historians and journalists have noted that words are being misinterpreted, misused, and redefined to discredit and illegitimize accurate reports (De Paor & Heravi, 2020, p. 3).

Given these keen observations, it is understandable then that librarians see innumerable informational injustices occurring, whether reading about them in LIS literature, publications from other fields, or observing them in the wild. Regardless of contrarian, clickbaity titles offered by LIS authors, similar themes can be identified in the solutions to misinformation that are offered. It does not matter whether a librarian feels combative or not if the efforts we are making are sincere, well researched, and evolve along with societal changes. The first theme with consensus is advocacy for libraries as places of public trust. Beene and Greer (2021) and De Paor and Heravi (2020) discuss building trust holistically by showing compassion and genuine interest in individual information queries even when facing sincere

conspiratorial thinking (p. 6; p. 4-6). The second theme is the need for librarians to re-evaluate traditional values when considering whether it is ethical to develop collections that include deceptive sources of information. This process is especially difficult when being careful not to step over the line into censorship (De Paor & Heravi, 2020, p. 5-6; Sullivan, 2019, p. 1149). Another theme is to continue collaborating with professionals, faculty members, public and private library systems, schools, and community groups in other disciplines to create scalable interventions to misinformation (Axelsson et al., 2021, p. 1; Beene & Greer, 2021, p. 4; De Paor & Heravi, 2020, p. 6; Saunders, 2023, p. 489; Sullivan, 2019, p. 1153). The fourth theme is to retire “information literacy” as a stand-alone concept in favor of expanding librarians’ focus to include an array of strategies. Some of the strategies mentioned include multiple metaliteracies (visual, digital, media), metacognitive training, critical thinking, lateral reading rather than vertical reading, analytical skill development, and civic online reasoning tutorials (Axelsson et al., 2021, p. 16; Bateman & Jackson, 2024, p. 27; Beene & Greer, 2021, p. 3; De Paor & Heravi, 2020, p. 7; Saunders, 2023, p. 488; Sullivan, 2019, p. 1153; Wineburg & McGrew, 2019, p. 4). The final theme focused on increasing the technological and pedagogical skills of librarians, especially those in academia. Authors explored the issue of censorship when using certain technological solutions that seek to certify information like labeling and real-time detection (Beene & Greer, 2021, p. 6; Saunders, 2023, p. 487-490; Sullivan, 2019, p. 1154).

Conclusion

There is not a singular solution to the problem of misinformation. Rather, there are many interventions that should be instituted in many different fields simultaneously. Librarians alone cannot solve this problem; it will require a much larger and interconnected effort to assist students and patrons in gathering the necessary tools to resist the waves of distortion in the ocean of online information. Bateman and Jackson (2024) published a table that depicts 10 different interventions, the extent of

knowledge on each, the efficacy of each, and the scalability of each (p. 5). The table illustrates that it will be necessary for individuals, governments, and private industries to work together toward scalable solutions. It also highlights media literacy education as one of the more significant solutions. Current and aspiring academic librarians can continue researching and sharing more scalable solutions by building strategic relationships with professionals from other disciplines and making an earnest effort to stay up to date with technological trends. Information will continue to become more immersive, more personalized, and more integrative because of technologies such as artificial intelligence. Naturally, this will increase the need for humans to continue being creative, intentional, and steadfast in how we respond when technologies do not serve our best interests.

Governments in other countries such as Finland, Denmark, and Norway are responding to this knowledge by requiring that primary school curricula include media and digital literacy lessons to protect children from the harmful effects of misinformation. However, only a handful of states in the United States require media literacy education in grade school by law. Knowing that counteracting misinformation is a long game, it stands to reason there should be a national requirement to teach media and other digital literacies to children in kindergarten through the 12th grade. Furthermore, the inclusion of digital literacy learning modules that encourage creativity and collaboration may contribute to the kind of social cohesion that will make media silos more apparent and less attractive to young people. Colleges and universities could institute core requirements or mandatory coursework on digital literacy taught by librarians as well.

Overall, this issue feels a bit like the parable of the choir. It is said that a choir can sing a beautiful note for what seems like an impossible amount of time. In reality, individual singers stop to breathe while other singers continue producing sound. Maybe teaching information literacy in the digital age requires that we not expect perfect, seamless instruction by everyone. Instead, we ought to allow time

for those who recognize their methods are outdated to breathe, catch up with advancements, and keep singing, rejoining the choir.

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